On Meetings

Every organisation holds more meetings than it needs, and every one of them began with a good reason.

A meeting is a promise that the people in it will leave knowing more than they came with.

When that promise is kept, nobody minds the hour. When it is broken, the hour is the least of what was lost: the people in the room were not doing the work they were hired to do, and the work waits for them.

So a meeting has to earn its place on the calendar, and the way it earns it is the subject of the next page.

Earning the Hour

The first rule is the simplest, and the one most often broken.

Some meetings are habits. They are held on a Tuesday because they were held on the Tuesday before, and nobody remembers what they were for.

Cancel any meeting that has no question to answer.

The second rule is about the end of a meeting rather than its start. A decision that is not written down is remembered three different ways by the three people who made it.

Write down what was decided, and send it within the hour.